machinery which he tactfully used to counter anti-India elements embedded in the system. A month later, External Affairs Minister Inder Kumar Gujaral, serving under the new Indian prime minister, V.P. Singh, landed in Dhaka. The Indian delegation met Ershad to discuss all the vexing bilateral issues including the sharing of Ganga waters. In the background, Patwardhan and his team intensified their activities to bring down Ershad, who was turning bitter and hostile to India. An Indian intelligence review in early 1990 viewed him as a long-term threat to South Asia, a man who was acting on the directions of Western spy agencies that were now deeply entrenched in the Dhaka administration. A prized catch within Ershad's government codenamed Ismail was welcomed into the Indian informers' network. He was asked to help recruit political leaders to spearhead a campaign to restore democracy in Bangladesh.

Ismail and Patwardhan devised a unique method to communicate with each other. Whenever Ismail had information to share, the opinion page of the day's newspaper delivered to his controller, Rakesh Dixit, Patwardhan's junior colleague, was torn in half. It indicated the need for a meeting at an old jute warehouse on the banks of the Buriganga on the outskirts of Dhaka. In March 1990, Patwardhan and his team achieved another breakthrough when a top army commander serving under Ershad gave the R&AW the names of ISI and CIA officers who exercised considerable influence on the regime. The CIA used slush funds to ensure that Ershad's proWest policy continued for decades to come. The then ISI chief Shamsur Rahman Kallue, loyal to Benazir Bhutto, was able to expand the Pakistani network with the help of the Americans and the nexus posed a formidable threat to R&AW operations. Sometime in May 1990, Ismail introduced a powerful politician